> a vast horde…was like a locust invasion: they simply ate up everything on their path or trampled down stranding crops. The greatest damage was done by camp followers, the rabble that constituted the bulk of the Mughal host, who stripped whatever they found on the way.

There were also additional tented structures, some eighteen described by Qandahari, ‘which have been made of boards of wood, each including an upper chamber and balcony…that are set up in a suitable and attractive place. The boards are joined up together by iron rings’. These prefabricated and movable structures were an innovation of Akbar’s and used an ingenious system of posts and beams which could be used to instantly fashion wooden housing. European brocade and velvet furnished the insides of the tents and on the floors, up to a thousand carpets made it look like ‘a garden had bloomed’. In the centre of the encampment was a high pole with an immense lamp known as the akash diyah, used by the camp dwellers to orient themselves, and was ‘the heart and head of the whole camp’. The farrash khana, or department of tents, carpets, and materials, contained two identical sets of equipment so that while the Padshah remained in one location, a second camp was being prepared in advance at the next stop.

Four days after leaving Fatehpur Sikri the Mughal camp arrived at Mathura, where Monserrate noted that ‘temples dedicated to Vishnu are to be found in many places’. These shrines were patronized by many members of the Mughal elite, and on the report of Raja Birbal, a grant of 100 bighas had been made to temples in the city. By the time the imperial army was passing through in 1581, seven temples of Mathura had been granted tax-free lands. In the course of the year, Hamida Banu was to issue a farman from Fatehpur Sikri permitting free grazing by the cows and oxen of one Vithalrai of Govardhan. Outside Mathura was a Hanuman temple with 300 trained monkeys who fought like gladiators with miniature weapons upon the ringing of a bell, which Monserrate derided as being a venal attempt by Brahmins to fleece poor and easily beguiled pilgrims.

Each time Akbar departed from the camping ground for another day’s journey, he was closely followed by officers carrying a ten-foot rod[*]—these officials meticulously measured the distance covered. ‘These measurements,’ wrote Monserrate, ‘are afterwards found very useful in computing the area of provinces and the distances of places apart, for